

TOUR DE FRANCE

EPISODE 1

A NEW START

written by

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EXT. ROAD - TOUR DE FRANCE STAGE - DAY

A country road battered by wind and rain. The road is lined with crowds of spectators who are all looking intently in one direction.

Suddenly they appear like blue and silver arrows, 8 cyclists with their sleek helmets peddling at full speed, with their solid back wheels and aero bars. It's the team time trial.

They ride at incredible speed, despite the treacherous weather. We see the name of the team on their jerseys: DEEPBLUE.

The muscles on the racers' legs are salient, their faces contorted by the effort. Two wheels touch, a fall is avoided at the last minute. One cyclist shouts at the racer in front.

VICTOR

Andrea! Keep to your fucking line!
You'll take the whole team down!

Another cyclist turns to look behind him, it's MATHIAS (35 years old).

MATHIAS

(authoritatively)
Calm down! We're a team.

In the DEEPBLUE car, ERIK (55 years old), Scouse accent, in a team polo shirt, is driving. MICHEL (68 years old), team manager, wearing a white shirt, is sitting in the passenger seat. They follow a few metres behind the team. The rain comes down harder. The windscreen wipers are swishing manically. There's zero visibility. The danger is omnipresent.

ERIK picks up the radio.

ERIK

Lads, the Australians are crushing
us!

MICHEL

(gutted)
Forget it, Erik... Mathias is
riding like he's got the brakes on.
At this rate...

One cyclist (who we find out later is MATHIAS) knocks another racer off balance and the whole group fall. The impact is violent. Shock all around. The whole DEEPBLUE team fall and collapse on the tarmac with a terrible sound.

ERIK swerves, only just missing a cyclist, and smashes the car into a tree.

CUT TO: BLACK.

TITLE OF THE SERIES

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INT. BEDROOM - RAPHAËL'S APARTMENT - PARIS - DAY

We can hear giggling as the camera slowly moves up two bodies moving under a duvet.

ON-SCREEN TEXT: several months later.

NORA (35 years old) and RAPHAËL (35 years old) are half-naked and their bodies are entwined. They are beautiful and in love. They laugh. The bedroom is spacious and bathed in light. It's an impressive luxury apartment. We can see Sacré Coeur through the window.

RAPHAËL

(teasing)

I can just see you with your bucket hat and pack of beer on the side of the road shouting "come on Poulidor"!

NORA

(laughing)

You know I only drink champagne!

RAPHAËL

(still can't believe it)

A cycling team! What's next? A sports bar!?

NORA

(complicit)

Why not!? As long as there's some money to be made!

RAPHAËL

Ah, I trust you on that one!

He puts on his luxury watch and looks at the time.

NORA looks at her phone, gets up and walks towards the ensuite bathroom.

NORA

I'm not going there to play nurse. It's a real business opportunity.

RAPHAËL

(from the bed)

Have you called your sister back?

NORA is standing in front of the mirror, her expression suddenly tenses.

NORA
I will...
(fed up)
She probably just wants to ask for
money, again.

RAPHAËL
(with a tinge of sadness)
How long will you be there for?

NORA
6 months. 8 tops. The time it takes
to put the business back on track.
But Brest isn't the other side of
the world.

RAPHAËL
It's a seven-hour drive. It'd be
quicker to go to New York!

NORA comes back into the room, looking radiant again, and
snuggles up to RAPHAËL.

NORA
We can meet for romantic weekends
in Dinard, it's halfway.

RAPHAËL nods but we can sense his apprehension.

NORA kisses him affectionately on the cheek and they embrace
again.

NORA (CONT'D)
(determined)
It will go quickly.

3 **EXT. SQUARE IN FRONT OF BREST RAILWAY STATION - DAY**

NORA is standing alone in the square in front of Brest
railway station. It's overcast. She looks classy, dressed
smartly and wearing makeup. She looks at her phone,
irritated.

Suddenly a DEEPBLUE support car speeds towards her, takes a
sharp bend and screeches to a halt, as if making a handbrake
stop, just in front of an immobile NORA. We recognise ERIK.

ERIK
Are you Nora? Sorry I'm late, I
had...

NORA doesn't let him finish and pushes her way through
equipment and mess to reach the front seat.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Don't you want to sit in the back?
There's more room.

NORA
It's fine.

ERIK
I haven't had time to clean it
out..

NORA
Are you an UBER driver or
something? Worried I'll give a bad
review?!

ERIK is speechless.

4

INT. DEEPBLUE CAR - OUTSKIRTS OF BREST - DAY

ERIK and NORA are in the car. NORA is on her phone.

ERIK
We're happy to see you. Since the
disaster, everything's been up in
the air. We're hoping to get back
on track this season but...

NORA
(firmly)
That's exactly why I'm here.

ERIK
You've got experience in sport?

NORA
(sarcastically, head in
her phone)
Oh yeah. I did two years of pony
club.

ERIK
(amused)
It's just that a cycling team is
very different and...

NORA
(interrupting,
confidently)
You're no different. I've been
saving failing businesses for 10
years, all companies are the same.
YOU'RE all the same.

ERIK has no answer.

NORA (CONT'D)
You're a sports director, right?
And what do you do exactly?

ERIK
My job is to get the best out of
our lads, and win races.

NORA
(provoking)
You see, my job is to get the best
out of your lads and...earn money.

The car pulls up on the docks and parks in front of the team headquarters: a huge warehouse transformed into a cycling technical centre.

NORA looks at it and the "DEEPBLUE Professional Cycling Team" sign appears in the reflection of the windscreen.

5 **EXT. BREST DOCKS / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

Someone is lying underneath the bus and making mechanical adjustments. We can hear them muttering to themselves.

NORA and ERIK walk towards them.

ERIK
Jenna, you got a minute? To show
her around headquarters?

JENNA (28 years old) quickly rolls out from underneath the bus on her mechanics creeper, beaming.

JENNA
(sarcastically)
Sure, Erik, I've got fuck all else
to do!

She notices NORA, well-dressed, professional-looking, and instantly loses her enthusiasm.

6 **INT. TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

JENNA and NORA walk at a fast pace through the hallway and visit the different rooms. There is some activity but there's no sense of urgency, nothing seems in its place.

JENNA
That's the admin office. The
canteen's at the end. On the left,
the GPP room, with weights,
strength exercises, etc. We also
use it for bike fitting.

She steps over equipment which is lying pretty much everywhere.

NORA
It's a real mess, isn't it?

JENNA
It's a tight squeeze, yeah, we need
somewhere bigger but...

NORA
It just looks really disorganised.
So, what do you do?

JENNA
I'm the team Swiss knife, actually,
I am Swiss. I drive the bus,
prepare the water bottles, fill up
the tanks, and I'm everyone's agony
aunt.
(suddenly mischievous)
And I lie to their wives...

NORA smiles, amused by her character.

Both women arrive at an office on the first floor.

JENNA (CONT'D)
That's the boss's office.

JENNA continues the visit but NORA walks into the office.
JENNA turns around, surprised.

7 **INT. BOSS'S OFFICE - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

JENNA walks in, NORA is already sitting at the desk.

JENNA
What are you doing?

NORA
I'm the new boss.

JENNA
(wide-eyed)
You're the one who bought the
team?! A woman boss! Sorry, but a
woman! Just wait till Thibault
hears about this!

NORA looks closely at the framed photos on the wall.

NORA
Just one question: who's the best
in the team?

8 **INT. AMPHITHEATRE / PALAIS DES CONGRÈS - PARIS - DAY**

MATHIAS appears nervously in the shadows backstage while a
speaker announces his arrival on the stage of a conference
hall decorated with TOUR DE FRANCE, in front of the biggest
figures in international cycling.

SPEAKER (OFF-CAMERA)
He has won almost 40 races in his career, double-champion of the Liège-Bastogne-Liège, the 2019 Vuelta a España, the 2021 World Championships, the 2022 Giro d'Italia, and came second three times in the Tour de France! The idol of a whole generation! Ladies and gentlemen, give a huge round of applause for Mathias Hofmaaaaaaaan!

MATHIAS walks onto the stage as cameras flash. He smiles, looking at ease now, and gestures to the crowd.

9

INT. PALAIS DES CONGRÈS / PRESS AREA - PARIS - DAY

MATHIAS is answering journalists in the press area.

MATHIAS
...but for me, the biggest challenge will be the Alpe d'Huez.

JOURNALIST #1
Have you fully recovered from your fall last season which cut short the careers of 4 of your teammates?

MATHIAS
I'm in good shape. It was obviously a real setback for everyone. And I'm thinking of them, especially Thibault who's not out of the woods yet. I'll be giving everything I've got for him too...

ANDREA (30 years old), tailored suit with fashion-week accessories, holding a fruit juice, walks up to him and interrupts.

ANDREA
"WE" are going to give it everything!

JOURNALIST #2
Mathias, are you going to need your most faithful teammate?

MATHIAS
(teasing smile)
I don't know if he's the most faithful, but he's definitely the most stylish.

The journalists laugh. ANDREA flashes a seductive smile before walking away.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
Andrea is like a brother to me..
There's a reason why my mother is
also his agent.

The camera moves to KATRINE (60 years old), elegant, dressed up, with a strict demeanour, watching from the sidelines.

JOURNALIST #1
There are rumours that you're
leaving Deepblue to go to...

KATRINE intervenes to put an abrupt end to the interview.

KATRINE
We don't comment on rumours. Thank
you.

10

INT. NORA'S OFFICE - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY

A meeting is underway in NORA'S office with ERIK and a few managers from the company.

We can see a dozen cyclists' faces on a poster. Four of them have a red cross on their face, including THIBAUT. At the top of the poster, there are question marks next to MATHIAS and ANDREA.

ERIK has a swatch of fabric in his hand.

NORA is listening, visibly irritated.

ERIK
...it's heat-sealed, they call it
low-friction yarn. It's not cheap,
but you can save two to four watts
in the wind tunnel and...

NORA
(irritated, cutting him
off)
Hang on, I've been here 5 days,
nobody is capable of telling me who
the real leader is and you're
talking to me about cloth?!

ERIK is speechless. Silence all around.

ERIK
The leader is Mathias.

NORA
Except I'm told Andrea's strength
performance is better.

ERIK
You can't define a leader just by
his data, it's more subtle than
that...

NORA
Then explain it to me!

ERIK tries to find the right words.

ERIK
In cycling, it's a collective
effort but the success is
individual, you see? That's what's
so unique about our sport. There's
nothing else like it.

NORA becomes more interested. ERIK continues.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Take football, even the guy that
stays on the bench becomes world
champion if his team wins.

NORA nods.

ERIK (CONT'D)
In cycling, when Bernard Hinault
won the Tour de France, he won the
Tour de France. Not his
teammates... But without the
support of his team, he would never
have won, you see?

NORA understands.

ERIK (CONT'D)
A leader has to get everyone to
follow HIS win strategy.

NORA
Then again, that's what his
teammates are paid for.

ERIK
It has nothing to do with money...
A great leader is a charismatic guy
who boosts the others, pushes them
further. And he's the one with the
strongest sporting performance.

NORA
(challenging him)
But the strongest is Andrea, right?

ERIK
Right now, yes, it's Andrea. But we
can work on that...
(MORE)

ERIK (CONT'D)
(more seriously)
I've been in this business for 35 years and I've never seen someone who works as hard as Mathias. But the rest of it: the charisma, the ability to bring everyone on board... you either have all that or you don't.

NORA
Ok, I get it.

After a while. NORA thinks.

NORA (CONT'D)
For your fabric, we'll make no concessions on the performance. But for your new team applicants, it's a no.

ERIK is about to reply but NORA continues, determined.

NORA (CONT'D)
I want the outcasts, the undesirables! Racers who no-one else wants. Because these guys will have something the others don't: a score to settle.

11 **EXT. STREETS OF PARIS - EVENING**

The click of gears changing on a derailleur. The swoosh of wind through the wheels.

AYDEN (20 years old), a good-looking mixed-race guy appears, he has a young and striking face, and he's ultra-stylish. He speeds through the streets of Paris on his bike. He's not wearing a helmet.

As a Deliveroo guy, he takes every risk to go faster but shows incredible dexterity.

He takes shortcuts, cycles down steps leading to narrow streets, enters and races down a tiny covered passageway, frightening pedestrians.

He crosses the Seine one way, then the other, once, twice, three times. Then he races through Opéra, Bastille and climbs the hill of Montmartre without showing the slightest sign of tiredness.

His technique is exceptional, he's enjoying himself. He weaves in between the cars which slam on their brakes, nearly knocking him over. People honk their horns, he changes gears and speeds off again without touching the ground, disappearing into a dark underground tunnel.

12 **EXT. STREET OF AN ESTATE - SUBURBS - NIGHT**

We see AYDEN still on his bike, cycling through an estate.

13 **INT. HALLWAY - HIGH-RISE BLOCK OF FLATS - SUBURBS - NIGHT**

AYDEN arrives in the hallway of a rundown block of flats.

14 **INT. AYDEN'S STUDIO APARTMENT - SUBURBS - NIGHT**

The door opens, AYDEN puts his bike down and turns on the light. The flat is small and very sparsely furnished. Cycling equipment covers the floor: chains, grease, tools and spare parts, a few dumbbells, a second-hand mirror.

AYDEN opens a cupboard in the small kitchen and takes a packet of *Pitch*.

He walks toward the mattress on the floor and lies down, his brioche already half-eaten, and looks at his phone.

Behind him, we can see posters of rap artists and BMX on the wall, but we hover on an old postcard of a road through idyllic landscape.

15 **INT. WORKOUT ROOM - MATHIAS' HOUSE - BREST - DAY**

In a modern, luxurious but impersonal house by the sea, we see a row of trophies, tokens of MATHIAS' past victories.

MATHIAS and ANDREA, bare-chested and in cycling shorts, are working out on indoor cycling trainers. They're dripping in sweat and giving it their all.

KATRINE walks into the house with MARCEL (9 years old), MATHIAS' son. MARCEL runs through the house and discovers MATHIAS and ANDREA on their bikes. The cyclists stop. MARCEL freezes.

MATHIAS
(as if caught doing
something wrong)
How's it going, little guy? How
was...

MARCEL immediately turns and runs away.

ANDREA
Things are no better with Marcel?

MATHIAS
(shaking his head)
The shrink says we need to give him
time. Since the accident, he can't
bear to see me on a bike.

KATRINE joins them.

KATRINE
(beaming)
I just got an email from Galactic.
You're both joining the biggest
team!

ANDREA
Bravissimo! Thank you, Katrine!

KATRINE
We just have to sort out the
details on the bonuses, but it's in
the bag. They'll be in the office
on Friday to sign the contracts.

MATHIAS
(not very enthusiastic)
Did you talk to them about Victor
and Réda?

KATRINE
(clearly irritated)
No, and I won't be. Their team is
already more than full.

ANDREA
(backing Katrine)
The most important thing is that
we'll be together. *Come fratelli.*

KATRINE nods.

MATHIAS
Have you told Deepblue?

KATRINE
I'll call them tomorrow and cancel
our meeting on Tuesday.

MATHIAS
(firmly)
No, don't cancel. I've spent 15
years of my life with Deepblue. I'm
not going to just disappear.

16 **INT. OFFICE / EQUIPMENT AREA - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

In the office converted into an equipment storage space,
among the bikes hanging neatly on the wall, NORA and the
managers have improvised a meeting room.

ERIK puts down a heavy pile of folders with satisfaction.

ERIK
Here are your unwanted guys!

NORA
(mockingly)
You know, you didn't have to print
"everything".

ERIK sighs with both irritation and a hint of complicity.

17 **INT. HANGAR CAR PARK / ANOTHER TEAM'S HEADQUARTERS - DAWN**

An old security guard enters the racing department of a rival Danish team. We can hear music and noise inside the bus parked in the centre of the warehouse: there's a party going on inside. The security guard knocks on the door of the bus.

18 **INT. OFFICE / EQUIPMENT AREA - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

NORA and the staff are listening to ERIK who has files in his hand.

ERIK
The Ledenmat brothers. Gaël and
Maël. Two hard workers, tough guys.

19 **INT. HANGAR CAR PARK / ANOTHER TEAM'S HEADQUARTERS - DAWN**

The door of the bus opens. GAËL (24 years old) approaches, wearing only the bottom half of a wetsuit and a diving mask, and holding a glass, clearly drunk.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
The problem is that, besides
cycling, they don't give a shit
about anyone or anything, and they
keep getting into trouble.

MAËL (24 years old) - his twin brother - appears, wearing the top of the wetsuit and his cycling shorts, holding a bottle of vodka, realises they're going to be fired.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
Three teams, three dismissals.
They're blacklisted everywhere.

20 **EXT. VELODROME - DAY**

WILLIAM (28 years old), with a huge red beard, is cycling at full speed.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
William McKinsey, the sprinter from
Edinburgh!

The sprinter starts twisting and turning, then unleashes his full strength.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
He's a leading track cyclist who
competed in the Paris Olympics.
Unluckily his chain broke during
the qualifiers. Turbocharged but
eliminated... On the road he's come
second 44 times, third 79 times and
0 wins.

Then a second sprinter pulls out and overtakes William.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
But with just his top 10 alone, he
could bring us hundreds of UCI
points.

WILLIAM stops. He removes his jersey. He is a real beast.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
And he's a monster. Nobody would
dare come close to our racers with
him around.

WILLIAM starts to scream in frustration like a madman.

21 **INT. LIVING ROOM - JOSÉ'S HOUSE - DAY**

A small 28 year-old man is sitting with a sad expression.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
José Correa, the "Calimero of
Medellín".

NORA (OFF-CAMERA-CAMERA)
He's always complaining?

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
No, he's just really small... He
was born at 4500 metres of
altitude. He's a pure climber.

NORA (OFF-CAMERA)
So, what's the problem?

JOSÉ looks sadly at a picture of his mother.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
He gets depressed when he's away
from his mother. And he's useless
at anything below 2000 metres.

NORA (OFF-CAMERA)
Does he speak French or English?

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
He doesn't speak.

22

INT. OFFICE / EQUIPMENT AREA - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY

Return to the equipment area / meeting room.

NORA
(convinced)
We'll take them. Good job, Erik.

ERIK nods proudly.

NORA (CONT'D)
(challenging him)
But there's still something
missing. The spark that will light
the fire.

23

INT. RAD RACE / WAREHOUSE IN THE SUBURBS - NIGHT

The atmosphere is electric. In a huge warehouse, there is electro music, flares, and a light show in front a crowd of fans looking for a shoot of adrenaline during an underground RAD RACE, an extreme cycling event on a go-karting track.

The first race takes place: the riders reach dizzying speeds, taking greater risks. The crowd is going wild.

NORA and ERIK arrive at the stands.

ERIK
Five bucks to get in? They're
taking the piss.

NORA
Actually, it's not that expensive.

ERIK
(irritated)
Cycling should be free. End of
story.

NORA shrugs and looks excitedly at the crowd.

ERIK
The lad we came to see is Arnaud
Guiblin. He made all of the french
youth team selections. He was one
of the best of his generation...

A rider suddenly makes a turn and smashes into a barrier, the crowd cheers, interrupting ERIK.

ERIK (CONT'D)
(continuing his spiel)
...but he quit over some stupid
love story. Girls always mess
things up for us anyway.

NORA smiles at his comment.

ERIK (CONT'D)
If you give him another chance, he
won't cost much.

NORA smiles and nods, looking at the racers.

Another race is announced. ARNAUD moves towards the starting
line. The excitement of the crowd steps up a level.

They make an explosive start! It's an insane and spectacular
race. ARNAUD is setting the pace, when suddenly, another
racer appears behind him: AYDEN.

NORA is fascinated, she doesn't take her eyes off him. AYDEN
emanates strength, power and grace all at once.

He forces his way through his rivals, quickly taking the
lead. He has no mercy.

He almost falls but manages to keep his balance before
accelerating again. The riders reach an insane speed, dicing
with danger. The duel with ARNAUD continues, but AYDEN is
stronger.

He crushes the competition with his talent and charisma. He's
radiant.

NORA doesn't take her eyes off him.

24 **EXT. RAD RACE / WAREHOUSE IN THE SUBURBS - NIGHT**

NORA and ERIK arrive "backstage" where the riders are
changing after the race.

ERIK
I'll introduce you to Arnaud.

NORA
I don't want him. It's the winner
I'm interested in.

AYDEN is fixing his bike, alone a little further away. NORA
strides towards him.

NORA (CONT'D)
Excuse me, do you have a minute?

AYDEN looks up in surprise.

NORA (CONT'D)
Congratulations on the race! It was
very impressive!

AYDEN
(smiling)
Yeah, it's fun.

NORA
My name is Nora Ménia, I manage a
racing team. You may have heard of,
Deepblue?

AYDEN is surprised.

AYDEN
Kind of...

NORA
Have you ever thought about going
pro?

AYDEN
(surprised)
Not really, why?

NORA
I'd like to offer you a contract.

AYDEN
(negatively)
Nah, working for others is not my
thing...

ERIK slips into the conversation.

ERIK
You should have hung back in the
second-to-last lap. You wasted your
energy for nothing.

AYDEN
(cheekily)
Maybe. But I still won, right? It's
all that matters.

NORA smiles at ERIK, amused by his wit.

NORA
You're right. That's all that
matters. You loved crushing them,
right? You're better than everyone
here, so why not compete with the
best?

AYDEN
(resolutely)
What, the Tour de France? That's
for white folks.

NORA
Not at all. Think about it, you've
got something special.

AYDEN
Nah, sorry, it's not for me.

AYDEN starts to walk away.

NORA watches him leave with his bike, weaving through the
other cyclists with their family and friends.

ERIK
Well, the kid's sure of himself.

NORA
(still watching Ayden)
No. He's scared. You can tell.
(empathetic)
He's all alone. Look.

NORA looks at him intensely. She's found her star.

25 **INT. OFFICE / EQUIPMENT AREA - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

NORA is sitting at a table. Opposite her is KATRINE flanked
by MATHIAS and ANDREA.

NORA
(formally)
Thank you for agreeing to this
meeting. It was important for me to
meet you and present the company's
new strategy.

MATHIAS looks at her intensely, impressed.

NORA (CONT'D)
There will be new elements in the
team...

KATRINE
(becoming impatient)
We don't have much time.

NORA
OK. I'll get straight to the point:
the Mathias and Andrea duo isn't
working.

MATHIAS, ANDREA and KATRINE are surprised and tense up.

ANDREA
(to Katrine)
È completamente pazza.

NORA
No, I'm not crazy! I've analysed
all your data, watched hours of
your races. With your qualities,
you should have won the Tour at
least 10 times over... but you
didn't.

Silence. Everyone is taking it all in.

KATRINE adopts an evil tone.

KATRINE
You've got a lot of nerve showing
up here in your fancy heels, but
you know nothing about this sport.

NORA
(not being defeated)
Actually, I know exactly what it's
about. Mathias and Andrea, you're
both huge champions... but not
together.

MATHIAS is surprised.

NORA (CONT'D)
I've made my decision... I want to
keep Mathias... but not Andrea.

ANDREA looks at her, expressionless.

Silence. KATRINE explodes.

KATRINE
In that case, you'll have neither.
It's over.

26

EXT. DOCKS CAR PARK - IN FRONT OF THE TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY

KATRINE, MATHIAS and ANDREA are debriefing in front of their
cars.

NORA joins them and stands in front of MATHIAS. She speaks
only to him and plays her last card.

NORA
Mathias, I'm going to tell you
something that nobody else will.
Right now, Andrea is better than
you.

MATHIAS reels. KATRINE wants to interrupt but NORA continues.

NORA (CONT'D)
I know you're both going to sign
with Galactic. But he'll be the
leader over there.

KATRINE exhales in exasperation. ANDREA realises what she's
saying. MATHIAS listens.

NORA (CONT'D)
Just ask your mother.

KATRINE doesn't answer. MATHIAS turns towards her.

MATHIAS
(angrily)
Well?!

KATRINE says nothing. NORA continues.

NORA
Over there, you'll have to follow
the pecking order and you'll never
win the Tour! The only race you're
missing. The one you've been
dreaming of since you were a kid.

MATHIAS is touched by her speech.

NORA (CONT'D)
With me, you still have a chance.
It may be small, but it's there.

MATHIAS thinks.

27

INT. AYDEN'S STUDIO APARTMENT - NIGHT

AYDEN is busy repairing the chain on his bike in the middle
of the flat when someone knocks at the door. He's surprised.

He opens it. It's a delivery guy like him.

DELIVERY GUY
Ayden Legrand?

AYDEN nods, he hands him a parcel and leaves.

AYDEN doesn't understand. He opens the parcel: it's a
DEEPBLUE jersey with a note: "You belong with us. Nora"

AYDEN looks at the DEEPBLUE jersey which is embroidered with
"AYDEN" under a small French flag.

AYDEN is touched, lost in his thoughts.

Shortly afterwards, he puts the jersey on and admires himself
in the second-hand mirror: it fits perfectly. He looks proud.
He thinks he looks damn good.

INT. THIBAUT'S HOSPITAL ROOM - BREST - EVENING

THIBAUT is lying asleep in his bed. Both of his legs are visible, one is rimmed with metal after an umpteenth operation.

MATHIAS is sitting in a corner of the room, looking sadly at THIBAUT.

JENNA is moving around arranging gifts and flowers.

JENNA

His thigh bone is too fragile. The bone graft didn't take. They'll be operating again in 10 days.

MATHIAS is sympathetic but looks sad, he doesn't answer.

JENNA walks towards Thibault and kisses him.

JENNA (CONT'D)

It's gonna be alright, Tib...

The door opens, it's ANDREA. He immediately freezes when he sees MATHIAS.

MATHIAS looks up at ANDREA. Moment of awkwardness.

INT. HOSPITAL CAFE - BREST - EVENING

ANDREA and MATHIAS are sitting opposite each other, stirring their coffee. The atmosphere is tense, foreboding. Each weighs his words. Like a duel with blunted foils.

ANDREA

(looking at his coffee)

Have you spoken to your mother since?

MATHIAS shakes his head, he has a firm expression.

ANDREA (CONT'D)

(uncomfortable)

What do you think about it?

MATHIAS

(firm and dominant)

I think you've been my most faithful teammate for 10 years and there's no reason that should change.

After a while.

ANDREA
(touched)
Can't you see me being the leader
at Galactic?

MATHIAS
(disapproving)
No. Not with me around, anyway.
I'll never be your teammate.

ANDREA takes it in. A long silence.

ANDREA
(choosing his words
carefully)
Do you remember the Stelvio Pass...
you were as good as dead, I was the
one who saved you. I sacrificed
myself, I could have won the Giro
too...

MATHIAS
Nobody forced you to.

ANDREA
(sickened)
I helped you win so many...

MATHIAS
I know.
(looking deep into
Andrea's eyes)
But when we come face to face at
the Tour, it'll be every man for
himself.

30 **EXT. SAINT-LAURENT PENINSULA - EVENING**

NORA is watching the sunset, calmly sitting on the bumper of
her car. The waves are crashing against the rocks.

She takes a swig of champagne from the bottle. She feels
good. Her phone rings. She answers.

CHRISTIAN (OFF-CAMERA)
Evening Nora. It's Christian, the
director of the Tour de France.

NORA
Hello, Christian, nice to talk to
you.

CHRISTIAN (OFF-CAMERA)
I don't have good news, I'm afraid.

NORA tenses up.

CHRISTIAN (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
I know you've worked hard to save
the team but... Unfortunately, I
won't be able to offer you an
invitation to the Tour this year.

NORA is no longer listening, trying to take in the news, in
shock.

CUT TO: BLACK

31 **EXT. BREST DOCKS / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

The Brest docks in front of the headquarters are quiet.

AYDEN arrives slowly on his bike with a large rucksack on his
back. Impressed, he stops for a moment to look up at the sign
above the large door, which reads: "DEEPBLUE Professional
Cycling Team".

32 **INT. MAIN ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

AYDEN walks around the interior of the headquarters which is
buzzing with activity as the staff prepares the start of the
season.

He looks around with fascination as he wanders around.

Someone smiling walks up to greet him: NORA.

NORA
Welcome to your new home, Ayden.

AYDEN flashes a shy smile.

ERIK joins them.

ERIK
Well, hello there! Ready for the
tests?

AYDEN nods, undaunted.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Would you say you're more of a
climber, flat racer, or sprinter?

AYDEN
(little cheeky smile)
A winner.

NORA smiles. ERIK turns to her, also amused.

ERIK
We'll see about that.

33

INT. LAB / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY

The staff are watching screens with AYDEN's live data. He is bare-chested, wears a face mask and is connected to cables on the other side of the window, carrying out a performance test on a connected bike.

MATHIAS looks at AYDEN then NORA who is standing next to ERIK and the staff who have their eyes fixed on the racer.

MATHIAS
(to an assistant, taking
off his jacket)
Get another bike ready.

NORA looks at MATHIAS.

34

INT. LAB / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY

Moments later, an assistant finishes connecting the sensors and fitting the mask to MATHIAS while AYDEN continues the exercise opposite him.

MATHIAS starts to pedal hard. He stares into the eyes of AYDEN who looks more intimidated. They are face to face.

The beeps of the machines set the pace of the scene and create tension.

ERIK and the staff watch the duel intently. Other members come to watch the face-off.

They cycle faster and faster. The beeps accelerate...

AYDEN's figures skyrocket. MATHIAS' stats rise steadily and in a controlled manner.

There's a buzz in the control room too. NORA watches the duel with great attention. The mumbles increase.

AYDEN reaches his max and cracks, bringing the exercise to a halt.

MATHIAS stops but in a controlled manner. He has the look of someone who is satisfied he has won.

In the control room, everyone is buzzing from the duel. NORA cracks a smile of satisfaction.

35

INT. BIKE-FITTING AREA / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY

AYDEN is waiting his turn in the bike-fitting room where mechanics are adjusting cyclists' positions on their bikes.

Three racers are already in position: GAËL, MAËL and WILLIAM. They're just wearing cycling shorts.

An assistant asks AYDEN to step into a vertical cabin.

ASSISTANT#1

Stand there, we'll scan you with
the laser. You can keep your
cycling shorts on.

AYDEN gets into position, feeling uncomfortable.

GAËL, MAËL and WILLIAM are chatting, not paying him any
attention.

GAËL

...it's always great to go home!

MAËL

Yeah, Denmark is so much fun.

GAËL

(to William)

You would have felt right at home
Ginger, with your pale skin.

AYDEN steps out of the machine, and gets on a bike next to
the others who are stilling pedalling while they chat.

GAËL (CONT'D)

Have we met? Where are you from?

AYDEN

Paris.

GAËL

I didn't mean, where were you born,
I meant what team.

AYDEN

This is my first team.

GAËL

You mean... This is your first
time?

WILLIAM

(with his Scottish accent)

Welcome to the circus, rookie!
Willy McKinsey.

AYDEN

Ayden.

MAËL

That's Gaël, I'm Maël.

GAËL

We're not related.

MAËL
Come on, stop it! You embarrassed
of me or something?

GAËL
It's Mum who's embarrassed of such
a loser!

WILLIAM
(to Ayden)
Was it you who did the VO2 test
against Mathias?

GAËL
I hear you gave him a real run for
his money.

AYDEN nods, non-committal.

MAËL
He's not the great Mathias of 4-5
years ago.

GAËL suddenly notices something about AYDEN.

AYDEN
What?

GAËL
Don't you have a razor?

AYDEN shakes his head. The camera moves to Ayden's hairy
legs. MAËL smiles.

MAËL
Don't worry, bro, we'll sort you
out.

36 **INT. MEDICAL ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

On the other side of a glass partition, while AYDEN and the
others are still in view, we see JOSÉ, VICTOR and RÉDA, bare-
chested. Assistants are pinching their skin with skinfold
calipers to measure their body fat percentage while MATHIAS
is getting dressed.

RÉDA
(with a southern French
accent)
Andrea makes my blood boil! Just
leaving like that, no message, no
nothing!

MATHIAS turns away from his friends.

VICTOR
(with a Belgian accent)
Screw him!

RÉDA
You're kidding! They'll eat him up
at Galactic! And Andrea is...

MATHIAS
(interrupting)
Forget him! He's ancient history. I
don't want to talk about him
anymore.

RÉDA and VICTOR nod, surprised and feeling awkward.

It's VICTOR's turn to be pinched for the test.

VICTOR
No need to worry about me, doc, I
only ate veg during the break.

MATHIAS
Beer isn't a vegetable, Tor'.

JOSÉ is subjected to the same test, the physical therapist
indicates that everything's fine. JOSÉ gives him the thumbs
up without saying a word.

ASSISTANT#2
(to Victor)
You've gained 3 millimetres of fat.

VICTOR
Three? That can't be right, I'm
starving all the time!

37 **INT. MAIN ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

NORA approaches nervously. Around twenty cyclists and members
of staff are waiting for her to make her first official
address. It's like the first day back at school.

NORA
I'm delighted to see you all to
officially launch the start of the
season.

Timid applause.

NORA (CONT'D)
The last few months have been very
eventful. Accidents are the worst
thing that can happen in this
sport. My thoughts are with
Thibault and his family.

The crowd nods sadly. We focus on JENNA and MATHIAS.

NORA drinks a glass of water and clears her throat.

NORA (CONT'D)
Some of you are probably thinking:
"What does this stuck-up Parisian
know?"...

A few complicit smiles.

NORA (CONT'D)
Well, the answer is: "not a lot".

The attendees are surprised and start to shift uncomfortably.

NORA (CONT'D)
I'm not here to tell you how to do
your job. What I'm good at is
identifying potential and pushing
it to its maximum.

Everyone is now hanging on her every word.

NORA (CONT'D)
We have something in common, you
and I, we want to win!

A few cheers. The atmosphere starts to warm up.

NORA (CONT'D)
And what I'm looking at right now,
is a bunch of potential. A group of
people hungry for victory,
determined to prove to the world
that this team is not finished.

Another wave of cheers.

MATHIAS looks at NORA with a smile. AYDEN is fascinated.

NORA (CONT'D)
I have complete faith in you all.
That's why I put everything I have
into the team—and gave my bank
manager a heart attack.

Everyone laughs. NORA is becoming increasingly relaxed.

NORA (CONT'D)
Each one of us will have a role to
play! And we're grateful that we
can count on a great leader who is
joining us on this adventure.
(turning to him)
Thank you, Mathias.

Applause for MATHIAS who responds with a smile.

AYDEN turns to look at MATHIAS with interest.

NORA (CONT'D)
This season is very simple, it's
all about the Tour!

A new round of applause, the cyclists are ramped up.

NORA (CONT'D)
But this year, they don't want us.

Everyone is disconcerted by the emotional rollercoaster.

MATHIAS tenses. The crowd starts murmuring.

NORA (CONT'D)
Apparently, we're not up to
scratch. We don't belong.

Silence.

NORA (CONT'D)
But we're going to prove them
wrong, they won't have a choice!

Some people perk up. Everyone starts getting restless.

NORA (CONT'D)
I've bought us some extra time,
until the spring, to prove
ourselves. So, there's only one
thing to do: we have to win PARIS-
ROUBAIX!

The excitement fades, everyone is gobsmacked.

NORA (CONT'D)
This race is our ticket to the
Tour!

AYDEN looks at NORA with admiration not realising what the
challenge involves, while MATHIAS is stunned.

38 **INT. OFFICE / EQUIPMENT AREA - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

MATHIAS is in the office with NORA and ERIK.

MATHIAS
(furious)
How do you expect us to win Paris-
Roubaix?! We don't even have a full
team!

NORA
We don't have a choice! If we don't
win it, it's over.
(MORE)

NORA (CONT'D)
You're the leader, only you can
make it happen.

MATHIAS
You're not serious! I'm not fully
recovered from my injury!

NORA
Johan Musew won it after destroying
his knee.

MATHIAS
He's a Flemish! I'm still in the
general classification! I had seven
months to get back into shape, not
four!

ERIK
Stop looking for excuses, you sound
like Andrea!

Silence. MATHIAS mulls it over.

MATHIAS
We've never won Roubaix, there's no
way!

NORA
We've never won the Tour either...

MATHIAS thinks a little and starts to calm down.

ERIK
That's enough talk. We won't solve
it in this office. Get your kit on.
We're going for a ride!

*The following are musical clip sequences which help build the
tension. The team go into COMMANDO mode to prepare for Paris-
Roubaix. They start a hard winter of training.*

39 **EXT. BRITTANY COAST - CLIP - DAY**

20 cyclists are riding outside in the rain. We can sense
their pain and exhaustion. MATHIAS is leading the pack. Some
are already lagging behind.

40 **INT/EXT. CAR BRITTANY COAST - CLIP - DAY**

ERIK and NORA are following their progress from the car.

41 **INT. TECHNICAL AREA / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - DAY**

JENNA gives AYDEN an altitude tent. He looks fascinated.

42 **EXT. LANFINS PASS - CLIP - DAY**

12 cyclists are struggling up the hill. They are doing a specific lactate exercise to test their pain threshold.

43 **EXT. LANFINS PASS - CLIP - DAY**

Around a dozen cyclists arrive at the top of the Lanfins Pass. Some fall from exhaustion. MAËL throws up.

44 **INT. TECHNICAL AREA / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - EVENING**

The last mechanics leave the building and AYDEN is tackling the assembly of his altitude tent.

A few moments later, he goes into the tent, it looks like a basecamp at Everest set up in the middle of the dark warehouse.

45 **INT. WIND TUNNEL - CLIP - DAY**

MATHIAS is on his bike, conducting the wind-tunnel test.

46 **EXT. TOP OF THE LANFINS PASS - CLIP - DAY**

AYDEN has his foot on the ground and is holding his bike in between himself and ERIK who is raging at him. AYDEN looks defiant and doesn't say anything, but we can tell he's fuming.

47 **EXT. TOP OF THE LANFINS PASS - CLIP - DAY**

The cyclists are freezing cold and are warming up with tea.

Assistants cut their earlobes to take blood samples and test their oxygen levels.

48 **EXT. COBBLED ROAD - LOCRONAN - CLIP - DAY**

The faces of the cyclists are contorted in pain while they train on worn cobblestones. AYDEN's hands are bleeding.

49 **INT. MEETING ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - DAY**

ERIK is teaching cyclists how to protect their hands with bandages like boxers.

NORA watches carefully from afar.

50 **INT. WEIGHT-TRAINING ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - DAY**

The cyclists are doing leg presses. AYDEN is lifting more than 250kg.

51 **INT. VIDEO ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - EVENING**

The riders are being briefed by ERIK who is miming attacks with his hands and showing them the best route through the Trench of Arenberg.

AYDEN pays great attention. So does MATHIAS.

52 **INT. VIDEO ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - DAY**

AYDEN is attending a very technical presentation about diet, with diagrams and calorie rations. AYDEN is completely lost with all this new information and rules, he's tired.

53 **INT. LAB / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - DAY**

Several cyclists with masks and wires are undergoing a VO2 test on a connected bike. ERIK and NORA watch.

54 **EXT. ROAD IN A BRITTANY VILLAGE - CLIP - DAY**

There are only seven cyclists left (the selection for Roubaix). Passers-by admire them as they pass through the village.

55 **INT. HALL OF FAME / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CLIP - DAY**

AYDEN is looking at framed photos including one of MATHIAS celebrating his world leader title. The reflection of AYDEN's face appears over the photo of MATHIAS.

CUT TO BLACK.

56 **INT. OFFICE / EQUIPMENT AREA - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

NORA is sitting alone at her desk in her office, it's pitch black and she's on a video call with RAPHAËL. She stretches, tired.

NORA

They're real warriors, I don't know how they can withstand the pain.

RAPHAËL (VIDEO CALL)

But they're all doped up aren't they?

NORA
I can assure you they're not.
Mathias is amazing. And you should
see how Ayden is hanging on.

RAPHAËL (VIDEO CALL)
The mixed-race guy?! Is he really
good or is it just a marketing
ploy?

NORA
Haha! No, he really has something
special.
(jokingly)
But I have to admit, he doesn't
hurt our image.

RAPHAEL (VIDEO CALL)
By the way, could you tell your
sister to stop hassling me?

NORA's smile disappears.

RAPHAËL (VIDEO CALL)
Deal with your own family issues.
I'm not a social worker.

After a while.

RAPHAËL (VIDEO CALL) (CONT'D)
(realising he's hurt her)
I'll be back in London on Friday.
How about a weekend away?

NORA
I can't. I have to look after my
team.

RAPHAËL (VIDEO CALL)
"YOUR" team!? Don't get too
attached, will you? You're supposed
to be breaking it up in three
months...

57 **INT. HALLWAY - WEIGHT-TRAINING ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS -
NIGHT**

NORA is walking down a hallway when she hears a noise and
sees light in a room.

NORA arrives at the doorway and sees MATHIAS alone. He has
just finished some strength exercises. He's sweating, we can
tell he has injured himself. She looks at MATHIAS' battered
body. His scars and burns tell the tale of a professional
cyclist.

MATHIAS
(confidently)
I've been watching you too...

NORA feels embarrassed. The tension is palpable but neither dare to take it further.

58 **INT. TECHNICAL AREA / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - MORNING**

It's early morning and the small town of Brest is starting to stir.

NORA is the first one to arrive and is walking quickly through the dark corridors when she hears a noise.

Inside his igloo, AYDEN is bundled up in his sleeping bag, practicing bandaging up his fingers in preparation for Roubaix. He has a brioche in his mouth. He looks like a kid.

Suddenly, a hand opens the airtight zip of his tent and the torch from a phone lights up a petrified AYDEN: it's NORA.

NORA
Ayden?! What are you doing here?

AYDEN
Jenna said it would be OK if I stayed here.

NORA
How long have you been sleeping here?!

AYDEN
Uh, since the beginning...

NORA
(sighing)
You've been sleeping in there for 4 months?! What is this thing, anyway!?

AYDEN
It's an altitude tent. It boosts your red blood cells...

NORA thinks for a moment, alarmed.

NORA
Have you eaten at least?

AYDEN motions to his brioche. NORA lets out a huge sigh.

NORA (CONT'D)
Come on.

INT. HOTEL / RESTAURANT - BREST PORT - DAY

AYDEN is sat at a table wolfing down a generous breakfast in a restaurant with a beautiful sea view.

NORA is drinking tea. She looks at him with amusement.

NORA
That's better than your brioche,
isn't it?

AYDEN nods, swallowing a huge mouthful of porridge.

AYDEN
Are you staying here?

NORA
(amused)
No, I've got a crummy rental in the
centre of town.
(complicit)
But as my mum used to say: a penny
saved is a penny earned!

AYDEN smiles.

NORA (CONT'D)
How are the preparations going?

AYDEN makes a grimace and swallows before talking.

AYDEN
(confidently)
The cycling part is tough but OK.
(suddenly irritated)
What's really annoying are Erik's
rules, tactics, race plans,
hierarchy, whatever...

NORA
(understanding)
It's a lot to take in.

AYDEN doesn't answer and grabs a croissant.

NORA (CONT'D)
Take it easy.

AYDEN
(charming and mocking)
Just one? We'll keep it between you
and me.

NORA
(complicity but firm)
I think not.

AYDEN puts it down begrudgingly and finishes his porridge.

NORA (CONT'D)
What do your parents think of your
new life?

AYDEN freezes a moment and then admits while eating.

AYDEN
I never knew my father... And my
mother... she died when I was 3...

NORA feels stupid.

NORA
I'm sorry, I didn't want to
intrude.

AYDEN
(reassuring)
Don't worry.

AYDEN continues eating his breakfast. NORA changes the
subject.

NORA
Are you stressed about Sunday?

AYDEN looks up, not understanding.

NORA (CONT'D)
Your first "Monument"!

AYDEN smiles.

AYDEN
You know what the "Monuments" are?!

NORA
(reciting)
Of course: Paris-Roubaix, the Tour
of Flanders, Milan-San Remo, Liège-
Bastogne-Liège and the Tour of
Lombardy.
(light-heartedly)
Did I forget any?

AYDEN smiles, impressed.

AYDEN
You're not that out of your depth,
after all.

NORA
It's my job. You know, once I even
took over a lighting company. Now I
can talk about every type of bulb
fitting, filament expansion
threshold and insulation beads.

AYDEN is amused.

NORA looks at him intently.

NORA (CONT'D)
You cycle fast. I learn fast.

60 **EXT. STARTING LINE TENT - PARIS-ROUBAIX - COMPIÈGNE - DAY**

It's the big day: the tent has been set up around the town of Compiègne: dozens of vans and busses are parked near the starting line. There's a festive atmosphere.

61 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS - PARIS-ROUBAIX - COMPIÈGNE - DAY**

The team is in the bus. The 7 cyclists are in their positions, MATHIAS, WILLIAM, RÉDA, VICTOR, AYDEN and THE TWINS. They're ready for combat, concentrated.

ERIK has started his pre-race brief. NORA is standing beside him.

ERIK
...we have 260 kilometres including
56 kilometres of uneven
cobblestones. With the rain and the
mud, it'll be more like a
battlefield than a race. And we
must win this. At all costs.

The cyclists nod.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Victor and Willy, don't let anyone
near Mathias. Réda, you're in
charge of fuelling. The twins will
counter any attacks. We won't let
anyone be in front of Wallers.
Nobody should be stuck between the
peloton and the breakaway group. We
pull in like crazy for the Trench
of Arenberg. Then, Mathias it will
be up to you to show them what
you're made of.

MATHIAS nods.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Ayden, you've shown us over the
last 4 months that you're strong
and agile. But you've also shown us
that you don't have a clue. So,
we'll make things simple, today you
won't be a racer, you'll be a
mechanic. You'll shadow Mathias.
(MORE)

ERIK (CONT'D)
Stick to him like glue from
beginning to end, at the slightest
issue, you give him your bike. Got
it?

AYDEN nods.

ERIK (CONT'D)
You've worked like maniacs and I
know you can do this. Come on,
let's smash this race and bring
back that trophy!

The cyclists are revved up.

NORA intervenes, on a more serious note.

NORA
The finish line at Roubaix is our
starting line for the Tour.

Everyone nods their head solemnly.

62 **EXT. STARTING LINE - PARIS-ROUBAIX - COMPIÈGNE - DAY**

The cyclists are in position on the starting line. They are
all focussed on the race.

MATHIAS catches the eye of another cyclist: ANDREA, who's
wearing a GALACTIC jersey. ANDREA looks away.

MATHIAS
(sarcastically)
There you go, you've finally got
your jersey with a "1". You're a
leader!

ANDREA
(evil)
I hear you might not even make the
Tour?

MATHIAS's smile disappears.

ANDREA (CONT'D)
It's probably for the best. There's
nothing worse than ending a career
on one race too many. Even your
mother would agree.

MATHIAS is furious. ANDREA focusses on the race.

EXT. COBBLED ROADS ROUBAIX - PARIS-ROUBAIX - DAY

In the scramble of the race, the small compact groups in the heart of the peloton are charging over the worn cobblestones, they're covered in mud. Like warriors.

The support cars and dirt bikes rattle behind, projecting spatters of mud in their wake.

A kid is holding up a sign for MATHIAS.

MATHIAS finally appears, his face is contorted by the effort and covered in mud. His eyes are red. He is alone.

The other DEEPBLUE cyclists are scattered around. Chaos reigns in the peloton. Everyone is suffering. It's Verdun!

NORA follows the race on a screen in the team bus.

ERIK is in a team car following them, giving them instructions.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
(on the radio)
Lads, get into a group around
Mathias. He's on his own again, he
shouldn't be!

VICTOR talks to GAËL who is near him.

VICTOR
Did you hear that, porky, move
forward for God's sake!

GAËL
Shut up! You think it's easy!?

Several cyclists have minor falls. VICTOR and GAËL are forced to put a foot on the ground. VICTOR blows up in frustration.

Ahead, the race continues. Still at an insane pace.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
Ayden you're too far forward.
You're no use to us there. Pull
back next to Mathias!

AYDEN appears, separated from the rest. He attacks the cobblestones, taking risks, as if he were riding across Paris.

MATHIAS edges towards ANDREA who tries to stop him overtaking. MATHIAS forces his way through, ANDREA puts up a fight and pushes him into the side of the road. A battle between brothers, they glare at each other.

ANDREA pushes him again, once, twice. MATHIAS falls. The fall is spectacular but without gravity and the mud softens the impact. ANDREA rides away.

MATHIAS gets up. He's uninjured but furious. He grabs his bike, searches for someone and shouts angrily into his microphone.

MATHIAS
A bike, quick! My frame's
destroyed!

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
We're stuck in the chaos here.
Willy is a minute behind you.

MATHIAS
1 minute?! Where the fuck is
Ayden!?

AYDEN has broken away, alone, some distance ahead, racing across the cobblestones. He's also covered in mud.

The tension rises, we can hear the rattle of his wheels on the cobblestones. The danger increases.

NORA looks worriedly at the screen.

Back to AYDEN, we switch to his perspective and the sound starts to become isolated: we can hear his breathing and heartbeat getting faster and faster.

MATHIAS appears, still at the side of the road.

WILLIAM arrives at great speed, skids to a halt and gives his bike to MATHIAS who has already jumped on. WILLIAM pushes MATHIAS to give him more speed.

MATHIAS is in a rage. Jaw clenched. Determined expression.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
Mathias, you're 1'10 from the
front. There are 80 kilometres
left, you have to catch up! Fast as
you can, kid!

MATHIAS accelerates hard, moves out of the sector, clips the apex on the bends, then speeds up again on the straights. He moves up each bunch of cyclists, passing them with lightning speed as the crowd cheers him on.

A cloth cleans the mud of the lens of the camera filming from the motorbike. AYDEN appears once again, at full throttle. He doesn't notice anything around him. The crowd goes wild.

Meanwhile, MATHIAS has joined the counter group (around twenty cyclists) chasing AYDEN. He has to catch his breath, he's exhausted.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
Mathias you're in the counter
group. Don't relay anyone. Ayden is
on his own at the front, he can
win.

But MATHIAS moves up the group, a hard expression on his
face.

NORA watches him on the screen. Her expression becomes tense.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA) (CONT'D)
Mathias, I repeat: don't take over!
Stay where you are! Ayden is in
front, he might have a chance.

MATHIAS moves to the front of the group and continues to
accelerate. Certain rivals can't keep up.

In the car, ERIK throws the radio on the ground out of
frustration.

Soon the chase group have AYDEN in their sight. He approaches
and overtakes him.

MATHIAS doesn't look at his teammate who lets himself fall
back.

The Roubaix velodrome is in sight. The crowd is ecstatic.

NORA anxiously watches them from the bus.

64 **EXT. ROUBAIX VELODROME - DAY**

MATHIAS is totally focussed for the final sprint. There are
only 7 of them left. He moves to the top of the track and
starts his sprint. This is it.

NORA anxiously watches the sprint from the bus. She stands
up.

KATRINE is watching from the middle of the velodrome.

MATHIAS is in the lead, the finish line is 100 metres away.

NORA is already shaking hands.

But suddenly, another cyclist appears on the side of MATHIAS,
he's larger, more stocky, MATHIAS can't keep up the pace.

The cyclist overtakes him 5 metres from the line and screams
with joy.

SPEAKER#1
He's won! Nino Jansen has won!

In the bus, NORA is dumbfounded, it's all over.

Shock. The team and staff are all devastated.

NORA goes to the finish line and catches the eye of a furious MATHIAS.

The winner is celebrating with his team.

65

EXT. BUS PADDOCK - PARIS-ROUBAIX - ROUBAIX - DAY

MATHIAS walks by the GALACTIC bus where he sees ANDREA with other cyclists and KATRINE.

KATRINE
You ruined everything by staying
with Deepblue.

MATHIAS stops, exhales, with his back to his mother, thinking.

MATHIAS
Can you help me?

He turns to face her, almost begging, like a child.

KATRINE
(coldly)
Don't stoop that low...

MATHIAS meets the cold stare of ANDREA, then continues on his way, on the verge of breaking down.

66

INT. VELODROME SHOWERS - PARIS-ROUBAIX - ROUBAIX - DAY

In the legendary concrete velodrome showers, a few cyclists have finished showering.

We see AYDEN, sitting alone in a cubicle, still in his mud-covered gear, a dark expression on his face.

MATHIAS arrives and sees AYDEN, he fills with anger.

MATHIAS
You're a real bastard!

AYDEN tenses up further.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
Thanks to you, we'll not be going
to the Tour! You might not give a
shit, but it's my whole life you've
messed up!

AYDEN
Why did you ride over me in the
other group?! I was on the way to
winning and...

MATHIAS

But that wasn't your fucking job!
If you'd have been there to help, I
wouldn't have had to bust my ass, I
would've been in their spokes for
the last three-metre sprint!

AYDEN clenches his teeth.

ERIK joins them.

ERIK

(sarcastically)

How are my two heroes doing?

MATHIAS swings around. He's furious, but doesn't respond.

ERIK (CONT'D)

(to Ayden)

He's right, if you'd done your job,
Mathias would've won easily... Once
again, you ignored instructions and
it's starting to seriously get on
my nerves!

AYDEN kicks a helmet and gets up to leave.

AYDEN

That's it! I've had it with your
stupid rules!

AYDEN leaves the showers as the two others give a knowing
look. ERIK turns to MATHIAS.

ERIK

And you, "boss", if you had stayed
in the pack as I told you instead
of chasing him, he would have won
easily...

MATHIAS tenses up.

ERIK (CONT'D)

What he did in the Trench of
Arenberg, pushing the peloton into
single file, that was really
something. That's the kind of thing
you would have done 10 years ago...

MATHIAS takes it all in.

ERIK (CONT'D)

You're both just as stupid as each
other. If you hadn't raced as
rivals, we would have crushed them
today.

EXT. BUS PADDOCK - PARIS-ROUBAIX - ROUBAIX - DAY

CHRISTIAN, the director of the Tour, comes to see NORA.

CHRISTIAN

I wanted to tell you myself. I'm
sorry but it won't be you. I'm
going to give the last invitation
to Curvistan.

NORA takes it in, thinking.

CHRISTIAN (CONT'D)

You fought well. It was close.

CHRISTIAN nods to them to say farewell and leaves.

NORA thinks. Then calls over to CHRISTIAN as he's walking away.

NORA

You're making a huge mistake!

CHRISTIAN

Listen, Nora, there are certain
levels of performance you have
to...

NORA walks towards him.

NORA

I'm not talking about performance.
I'm talking about inspiring people!
I'm talking about an epic story.

CHRISTIAN doesn't answer.

NORA (CONT'D)

We're going to give them the
greatest comeback they've seen in
20 years: the return of a broken
team, Mathias rising from the ashes
like a phoenix to claim his
destined crown. That's better than
Curvistan, and their advertising
breakaways...

CHRISTIAN thinks, not totally convinced.

CHRISTIAN

Do you really think Mathias can
still win the Tour?

NORA

I don't know.

She thinks a moment, then continues in a more serious tone.

NORA (CONT'D)

But if he doesn't make it, it will be like putting an old beast out of its misery. And it will be just as spectacular.

CHRISTIAN

That's cynical.

NORA

Maybe. But with us at the Tour, you'd win every which way.

68

INT. MAIN ROOM / TEAM HEADQUARTERS - NIGHT

A champagne cork pops and foam pours out of the bottle. JENNA sprays all the cyclists and staff in the room.

JENNA

We got in the hard way, but we're going to the Tour! It's game on!

Whistles and cheers all around. The cyclists drink a glass of champagne and take the opportunity to relax. They laugh and joke. VICTOR, RÉDA, WILLIAM and the twins start a karaoke session with the song "Bande organisée". JOSÉ watches them from a corner of the room, bobbing his head.

NORA watches the celebrations from the mezzanine floor, she has a smile of satisfaction on her lips, the expression of someone who has succeeded in what she set out to do.

MATHIAS's eyes meet hers, he starts walking towards her when someone walks across his path to give NORA a glass of champagne: RAPHAËL.

He hands her the glass and kisses her. MATHIAS stops in his tracks, but it's too late to turn back. NORA notices him.

NORA

(uneasy)

Mathias, let me introduce you to Raphaël...

RAPHAËL extends his hand, cautiously.

RAPHAËL

Her boyfriend... hi.

NORA

(still as uncomfortable)

Raphaël, yes, my boyfriend. This is Mathias...

MATHIAS

(Alpha male)

Her "leader"... hi.

RAPHAËL and MATHIAS shake hands. The start of a cockfight.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
(to Nora)
We'll talk later. About the
selection?

NORA nods and smiles. MATHIAS nods, looking casual, nods
goodbye to RAPHAËL and walks away.

RAPHAËL
(watching Matteo
disappear)
Her "leader"! What an asshole!

NORA looks on, embarrassed.

RAPHAËL (CONT'D)
Did you see the email from the
Koreans?

NORA
The sovereign wealth fund?

RAPHAËL nods.

NORA (CONT'D)
Now that we're sure to be on the
Tour, we've got the upper hand.

RAPHAËL nods. NORA ends it coldly.

NORA (CONT'D)
Set up the meeting.

RAPHAËL smiles, satisfied. ERIK joins them.

ERIK
Finish your glass, then we'll get
back to it, yeah?

NORA nods with a complicit smile.

NORA
Ok, boss.

ERIK
Any news of the kid?

NORA shakes her head sadly.

ERIK (CONT'D)
That's a shame. He was a real
dickhead, but you're right, he had
something special.

NORA nods, still looking sad.

INT. MRI ROOM / CARDIOLOGIST'S ROOM - DAY

The MRI scanner starts up and a patient's body gradually appears, uneasy and anxious: it's AYDEN.

Later, AYDEN is shirtless on the examination table of DOCTOR JOUCAN (45 years old). She takes an ultrasound of his heart, carries out a few measurements and looks at the screen.

DOCTOR JOUCAN

What have you been doing all this time? I thought you didn't want to see me again. You've been my patient for what, 4 years?

AYDEN

3. I had Dr. Montpellier before that.

Doctor JOUCAN nods.

DOCTOR JOUCAN

Do you still ride your bike?

AYDEN is uncomfortable.

AYDEN

Yeah, a bit. I got a job, but I didn't like it.

DOCTOR JOUCAN

You're being careful? You know you have to take it easy, no extreme physical activity.

AYDEN nods sadly.

AYDEN

Anyway, I gave it up.

DOCTOR JOUCAN focuses on the ultrasound and points to something on the screen to show Ayden.

DOCTOR JOUCAN

It's there. It hasn't changed. You really have to look to find it...

AYDEN looks at the area she is pointing at.

She hands him a paper towel and AYDEN wipes his chest.

DOCTOR JOUCAN (CONT'D)

I'm glad you finally accepted the operation. In six months, you can resume a normal life and your heart will be just like everyone else's.

70 **INT. OFFICE - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - DAY**

A portrait photo of MATHIAS is hanging on the wall above a sign reading "TOUR DE FRANCE Selection".

NORA, ERIK, MATHIAS and some members of staff are present. ERIK adds under the portrait of MATHIAS photos of VICTOR, RÉDA, WILLIAM, JOSÉ and the TWINS. Moment of anticipation.

ERIK

There's one seat left. Who do you want, Mathias?

71 **INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S ROOM - CROSSCUT - DAY**

AYDEN is sitting on one side of a desk. He is joined by the ANAESTHETIST carrying a small file, who sits on the other side.

ANAESTHETIST

I'll be your anaesthetist for the operation. I have one or two questions before we go ahead with the procedure.

72 **INT. OFFICE - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CROSSCUT - DAY**

MATHIAS

The one I want? You're joking, right?!

73 **INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S ROOM - CROSSCUT - DAY**

The ANAESTHETIST continues to complete the forms as AYDEN flatly answers his questions.

MATHIAS (OFF-CAMERA)

(getting more
enthusiastic)

I want a guy who'll push me to my limits! I want a guy who'll make the others eat dust!

ANAESTHETIST

Any medical conditions in the family?

AYDEN

I don't know.

The ANAESTHETIST hesitates but then understands, he jots something down, then gets up to leave. AYDEN stays sitting there, lost in his thoughts.

74 **INT. OFFICE - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CROSSCUT - DAY**

MATHIAS gestures at the photos on the wall. And gets more excited.

MATHIAS
These guys are all great, but
they're not playing in my league! I
want the best!

75 **INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S ROOM - CROSSCUT - DAY**

AYDEN is waiting in the office. He notices a painting of pastoral landscape on the wall.

AYDEN has flashes of Paris-Roubaix, being dazzled by the race and the crowd cheering, calling his name.

MATHIAS (OFF-CAMERA)
I want a junkie! A guy addicted to
the race's adrenaline rush. Who
would rather die than let someone
past him.

76 **INT. OFFICE - TEAM HEADQUARTERS - CROSSCUT - DAY**

MATHIAS
Not a cyclist...

77 **INT. CARDIOLOGIST'S ROOM - CROSSCUT - DAY**

The ANAESTHETIST comes back, AYDEN's chair is empty.

MATHIAS (OFF-CAMERA)
Not a soldier or warrior...

78 **EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - DAY**

AYDEN is on his bike, his expression is determined, focused, he races down a country road towards Brest. He's back!

MATHIAS (OFF-CAMERA)
I want a fucking kamikaze!

END OF PILOT